

Supplements That May Be Beneficial and Why

Note: we always recommend starting with whole food sources over supplements. In the world of supplements, less is more. On a case-by-case basis, supplements can be very helpful. That does not mean they are required for success. Each swimmer has individualized needs, and these should always be taken into consideration. **There are other supplements not listed here that may be beneficial to some swimmers, especially those with any known deficiencies.** These are simply the ones we most commonly recommend.

Protein Powder/EAA Supplement

How could it benefit me?

Protein promotes muscle growth and retention and keeps body composition at its optimal level.

What happens if I don't get enough?

Protein deficiency causes performance to suffer due to muscle breakdown and impaired immune function.

What should I look for?

Complete protein powders from whole food sources containing all 9 essential amino acids. Whey isolate protein powders are considered the "gold standard". You can find many plant-based options that contain all essential amino acids as well – you just have to do your research. Watch out for artificial flavors, colors, and sweeteners. Keep in mind, it's recommended that you replenish about 15 g of protein every hour of intense exercise (longer than 2 hours). Look for brands that are NSF, Informed Sport, or BSCG certified to ensure there are no banned substances. Look for these certs when choosing any supplement, not just protein powder. Some examples of brands we love: Garden of Life Sport, Vega Sport, biPro Elite, Ladder, Momentous, and Thorne.

Fish Oil

How could it benefit me?

It contains DHA and EPA, the two most beneficial omega-3 fatty acids. They aid in brain development, nervous system function, cardiovascular function, and immune health. They help combat a higher inflammatory response post-exercise, prevent muscle loss during an injury, and reduce symptoms of depression/anxiety.

What happens if I don't get enough?

Endurance and cognitive function will suffer. You could also be more prone to injury.

What should I look for?

Look for small-fish-based formulations (ex: herring, mackerel) which typically have lower levels of environmental toxins. Some brands we love are Thorne and Nordic Naturals.

Carbohydrate Supplement

How could it benefit me?

Carbohydrates are the swim athlete's most important source of energy for glycogen replenishment.

What happens if I don't get enough?

The body will fatigue quicker during exercise and will not be able to recover as well post-exercise.

What should I look for?

During a meet or long training session, supplementing with liquids, gels, or fruit chews is ok if you do not tolerate whole food well or have a back-to-back race. When possible, try to avoid artificial colors, flavors, and sugars. Keep in mind, it's recommended that you replenish 30-45g of carbohydrates every hour of intense exercise (longer than 2 hours). Some examples of brands we love (varieties WITHOUT caffeine): ProBar BOLT, Skratch Labs, and Honey Stinger.

Sports Drink

How could it benefit me?

Sports drinks replenish lost fluids and electrolytes the body needs to perform well for long periods of time.

What happens if I don't get enough?

Swim athletes may experience cramping, dehydration, headaches, and/or fatigue.

What should I look for?

Avoid sports drinks containing artificial colors and flavors when possible. Make sure it contains carbohydrates (from sugar), sodium and potassium. Every athlete loses a different amount of electrolytes during exercise. If you eat a very unprocessed diet (especially one that is low in sodium), you may need to replenish electrolytes before, during and after exercise. Athletes prone to "salty sweat" and cramping may need to add a quarter to one half teaspoon of salt to foods/beverages after exercise.

Multi-Vitamin/Greens Powder

How could it benefit me?

There is no replacement for a well-balanced, whole-food diet. However, multi-vitamins/greens powders can help fill in where the swim athlete's diet falls short. Athletes require additional vitamins and minerals to make up for an increased energy demand. Packed with vitamins, minerals, and antioxidants, multi-vitamins/greens powders can help keep your immune system (along with other systems) strong, prevent chronic health conditions, and aid with recovery.

What happens if I don't get enough?

Deficiencies in these vitamins and minerals can cause a host of problems – frequent sickness, injury, and impaired growth and development to name a few.

What should I look for?

Third party testing and a sport certification (such as NSF certified for sport) make it more likely that what is on the label matches what is in the bottle. It is also helpful to look at the form of vitamins/minerals, as some forms are more bioavailable than others. Examples of brands we love: Garden of Life Vitamin Code Kids / MyKind Organics, Thorne Kids Mutli +, and Thorne Multi Elite (for older athletes).

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